UNDP's Drought Response and Interventions in Zambia

Overview of the Drought Situation

Zambia is currently grappling with a severe drought, affecting 84 districts across the country. This crisis has led to devastating crop failures, escalating the risk of food insecurity. The youngest and most vulnerable members of the community bear the brunt of this crisis, exacerbating the need for urgent action. Community awareness of drought mitigation remains a challenge, emphasizing the importance of more robust outreach and educational programs to foster resilience among farmers and vulnerable populations.



A drying dam in Gwembe District
Picture by UNDP Zambia



Livestock drinking from a dam also used by Gwembe Residents in Gwembe District - Picture by UNDP Zambia

In response, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) has scaled up its support to Zambia, particularly through its partnership with the Office of the Vice President's Disaster Management and Mitigation Unit (DMMU). This collaboration aims to mitigate the adverse impacts of the drought and enhance the country's resilience to future climate shocks. UNDP's interventions are structured around three key Clusters: Risk Communication and Community Engagement (RCCE), Early Recovery and Resilience Building, and Energy.



Gwembe Residents in Gwembe District - Picture by UNDP Zambia

Risk Communication and Community Engagement (RCCE) Cluster

Purpose and Importance: The RCCE Cluster plays a critical role in ensuring communities are informed and empowered to respond to the drought crisis. Effective communication is vital to disaster response, helping communities understand the risks and how to protect themselves.

UNDP's contribution includes the provision of a dedicated risk communication officer to DMMU, enhancing the government's capacity to execute risk communication activities. This is improving awareness on drought mitigation strategies, ensure timely dissemination of information, and increase community engagement in resilience-building initiatives.



An aerial view of a drought affected area in Gwembe District - Picture by UNDP Zambia

Energy Cluster

Purpose and Importance: The Energy Cluster is essential for promoting sustainable energy solutions that enhance community resilience and support long-term economic development. Access to energy, particularly in rural areas, is a key driver of development, helping farmers and local businesses cope with the adverse effects of climate change, such as drought. UNDP's focus on productive use of electricity (PUE) through mini-grids will empower communities to use energy in ways that improve their livelihoods and increase resilience to future droughts.

Early Recovery and Resilience Building Cluster

Purpose and Importance: This Cluster focuses on helping communities recover quickly from the immediate impacts of the drought while building long-term resilience to future crises. Early recovery initiatives provide a bridge between humanitarian aid and long-term development, ensuring that affected communities can sustainably rebound from disasters. UNDP enlisted an international expert to work with DMMU on developing an Early Recovery Plan that lays the foundation for sustainable recovery and resilience-building efforts across the country.



Picture by UNDP Zambia